Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "white = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

White is the colour of **light, snow and milk**. A light surface reflects more light, lets shadows stand out and seems cleaner. That helps explain why white can relate to clarity as well as to the feeling that you must not spoil anything.

From culture

In Europe white is linked with **weddings, innocence and purity**, elsewhere with mourning. A coat, a duvet, porcelain, a gallery. At the same time it is the colour of healthcare and of empty new flats. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

Bedding at grandma's, the first white shirt, a hospital corridor, a new flat without furniture. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same white** and one feels relief, the other pressure.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "white" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does white connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

White has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

White on white

In **1918** Kazimir Malevich painted the picture Suprematist Composition. White on White, oil on canvas measuring 79.5 by 79.5 centimetres. Today it is held by the Museum of Modern Art in New York. The picture shows a white square, slightly tilted and shifted off centre, on a somewhat warmer white field.

According to descriptions, the white was to evoke infinity and the tilt movement. White here is neither emptiness nor purity. It is **a surface on which a difference can hardly be glimpsed, and yet it is there**.

White marble statues

Greek and Roman statues were often painted, especially clothing and hair. The colour wore off over time, so antiquity became a white idea. According to an overview this influenced eighteenth-century classicism and its white façades too. Traces of colour were found, for example, on the Parthenon and on the statues from the temple of Aphaia on Aegina.

André Malraux wrote that "Athens was never white". White was not the intention of antiquity. It was **the result of time and of our way of looking**.

The white that killed

Lead white was made from lead and vinegar and was the main white of European painters until the nineteenth century. It was used for underpainting, highlights and flesh tones. It was poisonous, though. In the eighteenth century Europeans whitened their skin with lead, even though they knew the danger.

It was later replaced by zinc white and titanium white, which was first produced in large quantities in **1916**. White became safer, covers well and lasts. Today most paint manufacturers expressly discourage lead white. It shows that **purity and safety do not always go hand in hand**.

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